

New Zealand School Sector

Student Survey for Schools Academic Year 2012

Summary Results

School Sector Overview

1. 107 schools participated in the New Zealand International Student Barometer in 2012; this represents 37% of secondary and composite schools in New Zealand who were registered to teach international students and who had international students 16 years and over enrolled in Trimester 1*.
2. Responses were received from 1,871 international students studying at participating schools, representing 27% of the total number of age 16+ students studying in New Zealand in Semester 2 in 2012*.
3. The School survey asked students how 'happy' they were, instead of the satisfaction scale used in other sectors ((universities, ITPs, PTEs and ELPs).
4. Overall, the overwhelming majority (94%) of international students studying at secondary and composite schools (aged 16 years and over) in New Zealand were either happy or very happy with their experience.
5. The School survey has no global benchmark group as New Zealand is the first country where i-graduate has surveyed international students at a national level.

Response

6. The largest proportion of the sample were studying full-time, qualification related study (69%) with a further 25% of students undertaking a study abroad or exchange experience.
7. When split by nationality, China dominated the sample, representing 35% of students who replied to the survey. This was followed by students from Japan (13%), South Korea (10%) and students from Germany (10%).
8. Although 86% of the sample were in years 12 & 13, it is important to note that only students aged 16 years and over were eligible to take part.
9. 79% of the sample were studying in the North Island.
10. Over half (64%) had started their course in the last six months.

Recommendation

11. 76% of international students would recommend their school to others thinking of applying. Of the top three nationalities, Japanese students were the least likely to recommend (61%).

Pre-Arrival and the Student Decision-Making Process

12. 91% of students were living in their home country prior to commencing study at their school in New Zealand.

13. When asked if they had visited their school prior to selecting their school of choice, 83% said 'no'.
14. Opportunity to improve language skills by studying in an English speaking country (96%), feeling safe (94%) and how people would behave towards them as an international student (90%) were of key importance when selecting which school to study in. These were followed by academic reputation of the school (87%), opportunity to go to a university or other school in another country (85%).
15. The school website (47%) was identified by the majority of the sample as the key influencer in their decision making process when selecting a school. Other important influencers were a printed document/guide from the school (31%), current students studying at the school (26%) and previous students who had studied at the school (24%).
16. When asked 'why did you apply to the school' – the largest proportion (49%) stated that their parents/guardian encouraged them to go. 34% also stated that an education agent/representative encouraged them to go, suggesting that the agent plays an important role in the decision-making process.
17. When asked specifically about the application process, 58% stated that they applied through an education agent.
18. Given the importance of the agent in the decision making and application process, the majority of students said that they were either happy or very happy with the service they received from their agent (88%).
19. 69% of the sample said that they were still in touch with their agent with 80% of the sample also stating that their agent had a contact in New Zealand. This suggests that the agent relationship does not end at the start of the student lifecycle but may continue throughout the student's study period in New Zealand.

Future Plans

20. 40% of students were looking to stay in New Zealand when they finish their studies and 42% plan to return to their home country.
21. The largest proportion of students (66%) plan to go on to university with a few suggesting they may go to another school (12%).

Arrival Experience

22. 81% of students indicated that they were either happy or very happy with their first few days at their school. However large variation exists between schools with a range between 53% - 100% happiness reported. When split by nationality, students from Hong Kong reported the highest happiness scores (91%) with those from Malaysia reporting the lowest, although this group was a relatively small sample size.

23. When broken down into individual elements, areas where students identified exceptionally high happiness levels were the school welcome (92%), understanding their timetable (91%) and help with using equipment e.g. computers (89%), with understanding the different ways of New Zealand (86%), getting familiar with the school (85%) and opportunities to meet other students/make friends for the first time (82%) all scoring the lowest. Indian and Saudi Arabian students reported more positive arrival experiences, however, the sample size in these nationalities was relatively small. In comparison, South Korean students, who make up a substantial part of the sample, reported lower scores, with all arrival elements scoring just at or below the benchmark.

Learning Experience

24. 91% of respondents stated that they were either happy or very happy with their experience of learning at their school.
25. At least 80% of students were happy or very happy on every element of their learning experience as all elements showed 80% or above happiness rating. Areas showing the highest happiness scores include: classrooms (94%), study leave** (93%) the subject knowledge of the teachers (93%), the technology used in the classroom e.g. whiteboard and computers (92%) and the library (92%).
26. Further study/careers advice received the lowest happiness score (82%) however students identified this area as one of the most important areas of the learning experience. In addition there is high correlation between whether the student would recommend their experience and their happiness with this particular area.
27. The majority of students (89%) were happy with the choice of subjects on offer at their school.
28. When asked whether students found it easy to be taught in English, a significant number of students reported that they found it either difficult or very difficult (38%).

Living Experience

29. A high proportion of students were happy with their current living arrangements with 92% reporting either happy or very happy. The majority indicated that they were living in homestay accommodation (69%).
30. Living elements showing the highest happiness ratings include: opportunities to make friends from other countries (95%), relationship with their homestay family (94%), help from homestay family on issues other than study (93%), quality of accommodation (92%) and food (91%).
31. Opportunities to make friends with New Zealand students received the lowest happiness rating (76%). Other areas showing relatively low happiness scores were: the school bus service (76%), facilities for religious worship (76%) and internet access at school (79%). These elements are very similar to the elements reporting low satisfaction in other sectors in New Zealand***.
32. The data showed no significant issues with perceptions on safety with the majority of respondents stating that they felt fairly safe or safe in their surroundings, especially within the classroom (97%) and the school grounds (94%). A small percentage of respondents reported that they did not feel

safe on public transport (14%) or in public spaces (18%). This is slightly higher than the safety picture reported in other sectors.

33. When asked how many close friends students had with various groups of people the survey showed that 92% of international students had made one or more close friends with people from other countries, 93% people from their own country and 82% from New Zealand. This suggests a relatively high degree of integration between international and domestic students especially compared to the other sectors in the study.

34. When asked about bullying the majority reported that they had not experienced bullying by anyone at their school (75%). 6% reported that they had experienced bullying and 13% agreed that they had seen others being bullied at their school. Of the small proportion who had experienced bullying only a third of them had reported it to the school – 64% of which said that they were happy with how the school had responded to the bullying.

Support Experience

35. 94% of respondents reported that they were happy with the overall support that they had received from their school with the majority of schools receiving 80% or above happiness rating.

36. Services which were reported to be used the most were: catering, the international office and IT support. Of these the international office received the highest happiness rating (97%) and catering the lowest (90%) but all the elements in this category achieved 90% or above happiness. With the exception of three schools, all received 80% or above with the majority scoring 90+% happiness in the overall support experience.

*At 30 June 2012, there were 902 schools in total that were eligible to have international students..

**Study Leave only asked of exchange/visiting students.

***Difficult to make direct comparisons with the other sectors in the study (universities, ITPs, PTEs and ELPs) as the School survey used happiness rather than satisfaction however broad similarities have been identified although not statistically supported.